

Usage Research

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Part 2 addresses the lifecycle activity of understanding user needs. To understand user needs, the UX professional must understand the work and work practice, including work roles, challenges in current practice, breakdowns and workarounds, inefficiencies, constraints, regulations, culture, so on. The primary method described for obtaining this broad range of understanding is usage research. Other approaches are variations and abbreviations of the usage research method.

The foundation of our material on usage research goes back to the work of Karen Holtzblatt and others on contextual inquiry and contextual design (Beyer & Holtzblatt, 1997; Holtzblatt, Wendell, & Wood, 2004). Another influence was Constantine and Lockwood (1999).

This lifecycle activity of understanding user needs begins with usage research data elicitation, usually accomplished through observing and interviewing people in user work roles. Data elicitation is best done in the real work environment.

Next is usage research analysis, which involves distilling the essence of usage research data into elemental work activity notes, extracting work activity notes that are inputs to user stories, requirements, and usage research data models.

The remaining work activity notes can be organized via a work activity affinity diagram, a bottom-up technique for organizing lots of disparate pieces of usage research data into a hierarchical structure.

The UX practitioner brings it all together to synthesize a full understanding of user work practice, the work domain, and user needs.